encouragement, was to rankle his conservative courtiers and ulema more than ever before.

The best-known example of the Jesuits in furious debate with Muslim theologians is the ‘Fire Test’, recounted by several chroniclers of the time, from Badauni to Father Monserrate himself.

Each tells it in his own way. In Badauni’s version, it began when one Shaikh Qutubuddin, brought to court at Akbar’s orders and set to debate the Jesuits, invited them to undertake a trial by fire with him. ‘The Shaikh pulled one of the Christian priests by the coat, and said to him, “Come on, in the name of God!”’ Whichever of them practised the true faith would escape the flames unscathed. The priests were too scared to accept, writes Badauni, and the shaikh was soon after exiled to Sindh.[6]

Abul Fazl, on the other hand, writes that it was Padre Rudolf, a ‘Nazarene [sage] . . . singular for his understanding and ability’, who dared the ‘untruthful bigots’ that he was debating to walk into a roaring fire with him, each holding their holy books, leaving the rest to God. ‘The liverless and black-hearted fellows wavered,’ Abul Fazl concludes mercilessly, ‘and in reply to the challenge had recourse to . . . wrangling.’[7]

Finally, there is Monserrate’s version. According to this, the most detailed of the three tellings, the Fathers had launched a full-scale attack on the ‘haughty pride’ of the Prophet Muhammad. At this, the Muslims proposed a trial by fire; a proposal that Akbar seconded with some enthusiasm – he ‘urged the same course upon the priests’ – but the Jesuits refused. Annoyed, Akbar got up and left.

Monserrate is quick to add that they did not refuse from cowardice. On the contrary, Rudolf ‘eagerly sought’ any opportunity to martyr himself.[8] It wasn’t that he didn’t want to enter the fire, it’s just that ‘he was in doubt as to its rightness at present’.

Soon after, in a private conference with a clearly disappointed emperor, Rudolf gathered his wits and declared that he and his companions would gladly enter ‘not one but a thousand pyres’ – and they didn’t even care if they burned alive in them. Why just fire, he went on, carried away by his own eloquence, ‘Trusting in divine aid, we have no fear of elephants, lions, panthers, leopards, precipices, crosses, stripes, and all manner of tortures.’ Let the flames be lit!